by timely withdrawals to keep out of harm's way and avoid disaster and shameful incidents such as that which has just occurred...I must absolutely decline to continue to share responsibility for a policy of mere bluff.'[49] On 18 June both Wilson and Churchill continued to press their views, warning that should the Cabinet ignore their advice and 'decide to continue the attempt to maintain simultaneously our existing commitments at Constantinople, Palestine, Mesopotamia and Persia, the possibility of disaster occurring in any or all of these theatres must be faced, and the likelihood of this will increase every day'.[50] As Wilson noted in his diary, however, his recommendation to withdraw from Persia 'brought Curzon and Milner to their feet, and it was quite clear they would resign if it was done'.[51] In a letter to Curzon a few days after the Enzeli attack, Churchill vented some of his frustrations: 'It is a great pity that we have not been able to develop any common policy between W.O. and F.O. I have to bear the abuse of F.O. policy and to find the money for it. Yet there is no effective co-operation or mutual support.'[52]

The humiliation of the events of May 1920 was compounded for Britain by the ultimate failure to convert the Anglo-Persian Agreement into a meaningful relationship between the two nations. Indeed, the hostility of the Persian public to the agreement was a demonstration of the low standing that Britain now appeared to have in that country. The prevailing belief that by the agreement Persia had become a British protectorate was one that both Cox and his successor, Herman Norman, found hard to counter, particularly when it was coupled with the accusation that Persian government figures had received bribes from the British government in exchange for supporting the agreement.[53] Public opposition to the agreement came from many sections of Persian society, including religious leaders, constitutionalists, nationalists, journalists, civil servants and even poets.[54] As one contemporary observed: 'The entire Near and Middle East is in the grip of Anglophobia, which unites the Muslims from India to Turkey, from Turkestan to the Persian Gulf.'[55] In trying to force British patronage on the Persian people, Curzon had simply failed to grasp the idea that 'The Orient of 1919 was completely changed from the Orient of 1890'.[56]